

THE MIDDLE EAST II

THIS SECTION OF THE MIDDLE EAST is in southwestern Asia and is covered primarily by dry, barren desert or rugged mountains. Ingenious irrigation techniques direct river water onto fields, and desalination plants are used to make seawater drinkable. In the 20th century, large deposits of oil were discovered around the Persian Gulf. Today, oil is the main source of income for many Middle Eastern countries. The majority of the population is Muslim and the most widely spoken language is Arabic. In recent years, the region has suffered a series of wars and conflicts between neighboring countries.

Sand dunes are created by a buildup of sand carried along by strong winds.

Sandstorms arise when strong winds blow sand and dust across the desert, obscuring the sky.

ROCKY DESERT

Part of the Middle East is rocky desert, where bare rock has been stripped clean by intense heat, drying winds, and occasional but heavy rainstorms.

Settlements may grow up around oases – these are often created by water coming to the surface through a fault (split) in the rock.

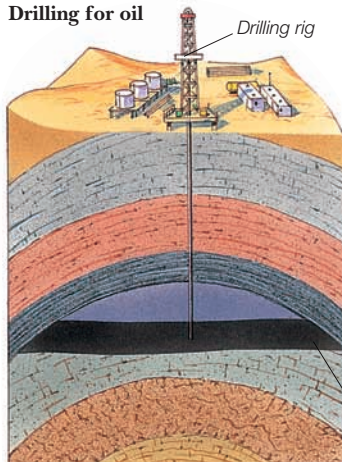
DESERT

Aside from fertile patches of land along the Tigris and Euphrates rivers, by the coast, and near isolated oases, much of this region is covered by hot, dry deserts, both rocky and sandy. These include the Rub'Al Khali, or Empty Quarter, a vast sandy desert in Saudi Arabia. Large areas of desert are uninhabited because of the lack of water for drinking and farming.

OIL PRODUCTION

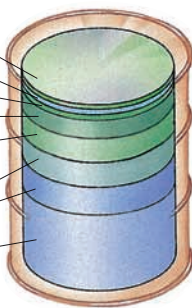
More than 65 percent of the world's oil is found in the Middle East, and the region supplies almost a third of the world's daily oil production. The discovery of oil has brought great wealth to the Middle East, leading to rapid industrial and social change in a formerly underdeveloped region. It has also greatly increased the region's international importance and influence on world affairs.

Drilling for oil



Distribution of oil production in the Middle East

Yemen and Bahrain: 2.1%
Qatar: 3.7%
Oman: 4.9%
Iraq: 8.3%
Kuwait: 10.3%
United Arab Emirates: 11.3%
Iran: 16.8%
Saudi Arabia: 42.6%



Oil wells are drilled deep down into the ground to extract the oil trapped between layers of rock.

WARFARE

In recent years, the Middle East has been frequently troubled by wars, in which thousands of people have lost their lives. In 1980, the long-standing rivalry and border dispute between Iran and Iraq erupted into a war that lasted until 1988. In 1991 and again in 2003, an international force led by the US attacked Iraq, overthrowing its dictator, Saddam Hussein.



Rusting tanks in Iraq serve as a reminder of recent warfare.



A sign marks part of the border between Iran and Iraq.

DISPUTED BORDERS

Many Middle Eastern countries are relatively new, created in the 20th century when the region was divided up by its Western rulers. These artificial divisions, sometimes poorly defined, have led to many border disputes, especially between Iraq and its six neighboring countries.